UNION EQUIPMENT

The Union infantryman's equipment pack – containing up to 80 rounds of ammunition, three days' worth of rations, rifle, clothing, shelter, and personal effects – could weigh up to 23kg (50lb). New soldiers quickly learned what was necessary for them to carry and what was less important. Campaigns in the early spring always began with full knapsacks, but the roads were soon littered with overcoats, blankets, extra clothing, and shelter tents that had been tossed aside to lighten the load.

Ramrod

Springfield 1861 rifle-musket and bayonet
The Springfield was the most widely used US army weapon during the Civil War, favoured for its range (some 600m, or 2,000ft), accuracy, and reliability. It used the percussion cap system that had superseded the flintlock in the 1840s. The musket came with a three-sided spike bayonet.

Shoulder sling

Three-sided spike

Rope
The Union infantryman carried a length of rope primarily for his shelter when he made camp. The rope would be secured between two trees and the shelter placed over it.

Sleeping cap
Personal items such as this sleeping cap would have provided the raw Union recruit with a semblance of comfort (keeping his head warm at night) in what were otherwise highly oppressive conditions.

COFFEE ESSENCE POWDER

BLOCK OF TEA

WOODEN-HANDLED KNIFE AND FORK

Loop of wire to hang mug over fire

TIN DRINKING MUG

IMPROVISED FRYING PAN

WATER-BOILING CONTAINER

Eating and cooking kit
The Union soldier's cooking kit was predictably basic but the inclusion of coffee essence and tea did provide some flavour to hot water. Typically, the infantryman would carry three days' rations at a time (usually salted pork) but would invariably consume it all on the first day, thereafter subsisting on berries.

Blanket

Rawhide straps

Painted canvas